



Literacy and closing the reading gap

Session Objectives

1. Look at the position of literacy within the curriculum as one of shared professional responsibility
2. Critically discuss research into improving literacy outcomes and closing the reading gap
3. Consider ways to address inequalities in literacy attainment within our subject disciplines

Essential Readings

Department for Education
(2023) *The Reading
Framework*

1. Machin, S., McNally, S., & Viarengo, M. (2018) Changing how literacy is taught: Evidence on synthetic phonics. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 10(2), pp.217-241. <https://doi.org/10.1257/pol.20160514>.
2. Moss, G. (2021) Literacies and social practice: sociological perspectives on reading research, *Education 3-13*, 49(1), pp. 41-51, DOI: [10.1080/03004279.2020.1824701](https://doi.org/10.1080/03004279.2020.1824701)
3. Education Endowment Foundation (2018) Improving Literacy in Secondary Schools Guidance Report. [Online] Accessible from: <https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/education-evidence/guidance-reports/literacy-ks3-ks4> [retrieved 17 August 2023].

Subject and Curriculum

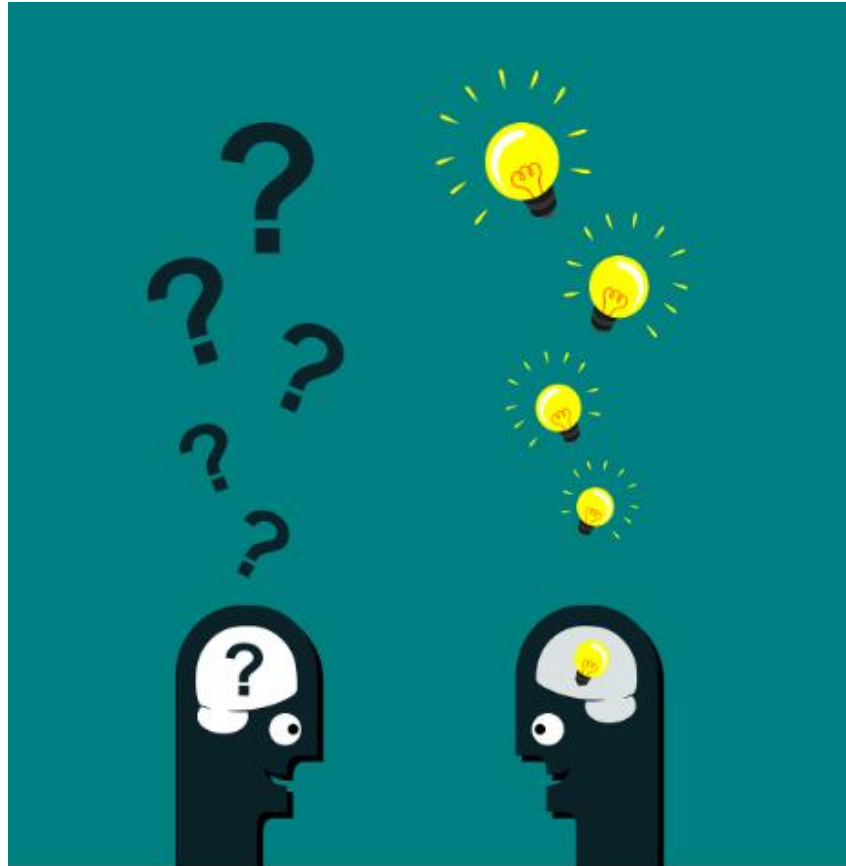
To access the curriculum, early literacy provides fundamental knowledge; reading comprises two elements: word reading and language comprehension; systematic synthetic phonics is the most effective approach for teaching pupils to decode (ITTECF3.9)

Every teacher can improve pupils' literacy, including by explicitly teaching reading, writing and oral language skills specific to individual disciplines (ITTECF3.10)

Considering our own language...

1. Do you have a favourite 'filler' that you use a lot – e.g. 'you know', 'I mean', 'like', 'well', 'um', 'er'?
2. Do you have particular words for 'good' and 'bad'?
3. Do you have words and phrases that you like, and use a lot as a teacher? (What words/phrases would your students say were typical of you?)
4. Are there certain words that you have trouble pronouncing or writing, or whose meaning you have trouble remembering within your subject specialism?

Why is it important to consider our own literacies
in initial teacher training?





Your language is unique, like your fingerprints.

(Goddard, Keen, Shuttleworth and Green, 1991)



Disciplinary Literacy

*What is unique about
your subject discipline
in terms of*
Speaking and Listening?
Reading?
Writing?



A disciplinary literacy model (EEF, 2018)

Recommendation 1	Prioritise 'disciplinary literacy' across the curriculum	6	
Recommendation 2	Provide targeted vocabulary instruction in every subject	10	
Recommendation 3	Develop students' ability to read complex academic texts	14	
Recommendation 4	Break down complex writing tasks	18	
Recommendation 5	Combine writing instruction with reading in every subject	22	
Recommendation 6	Provide opportunities for structured talk	26	
Recommendation 7	Provide high quality literacy interventions for struggling students	30	

What is literacy?

In 2001, George Bush suggested: 'You teach a child to read and he or her will be able to pass a literacy test.'

(cited in Yandell, 2008, p.2)

What is literacy?

Young people who leave school without good literacy skills are held back at every stage of life. Their outcomes are poorer on almost every measure, from health and wellbeing, to employment and finance. The most recent estimates suggest that low levels of literacy cost the UK economy at least £20 billion a year.

(EEF, 2018, foreword by Sir Kevan Collins)



(Wong, 2021)

What is literacy?

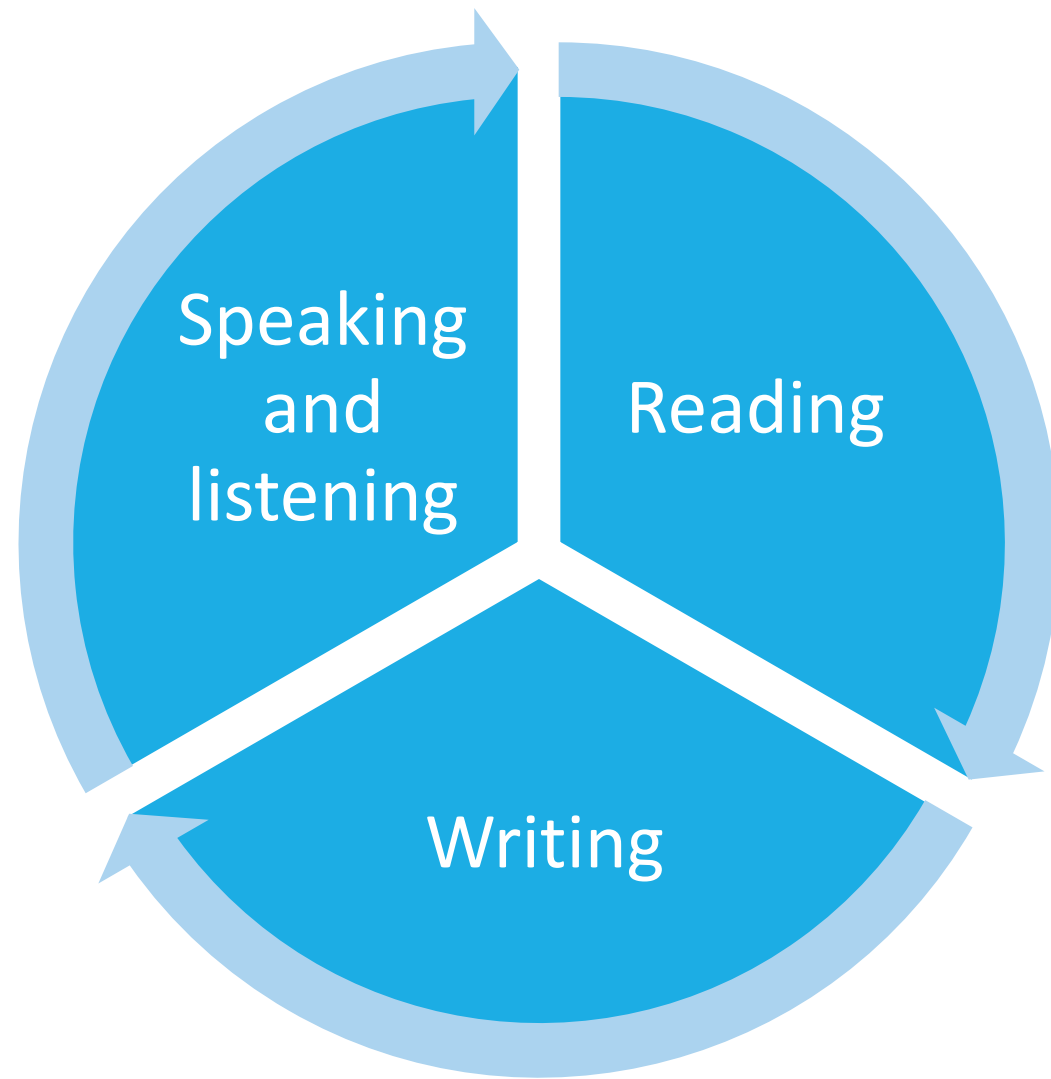
Beliefs about language are tied up with
beliefs about moral ways to live.

(McEnery, 2006)

What is literacy?

Literacy is the ability to read, write, speak and listen in a way that lets us communicate effectively and make sense of the world.





How have you experienced speaking and listening modelled and developed in your subject discipline

- Lessons you have observed?
- Lessons you have taught?



Back-and-forth
interactions with
children...

...Form the
foundations for
language and
cognitive
development

- thinking out loud, modelling new language for children
- paying close attention to what the children say
- rephrasing and extending what the children say
- validating the children's attempts at using new vocabulary and grammar by rephrasing what children say if necessary
- asking closed and open questions
- answering the children's questions
- explaining why things happen
- deliberately connecting current and past events ('Do you remember when...?')
- providing models of accurate grammar
- extending children's vocabulary and explaining new words
- connecting one idea or action to another
- helping children to articulate ideas in well-formed sentences.

(DfE, 2023, p.23)



The importance of reading

The simple view of reading

Reading has been described as the product of decoding and comprehension, a model first proposed by Gough and Tunmer in 1986, who called it the Simple View of Reading.

Children need both good **language comprehension** and good **word reading** to become good readers.

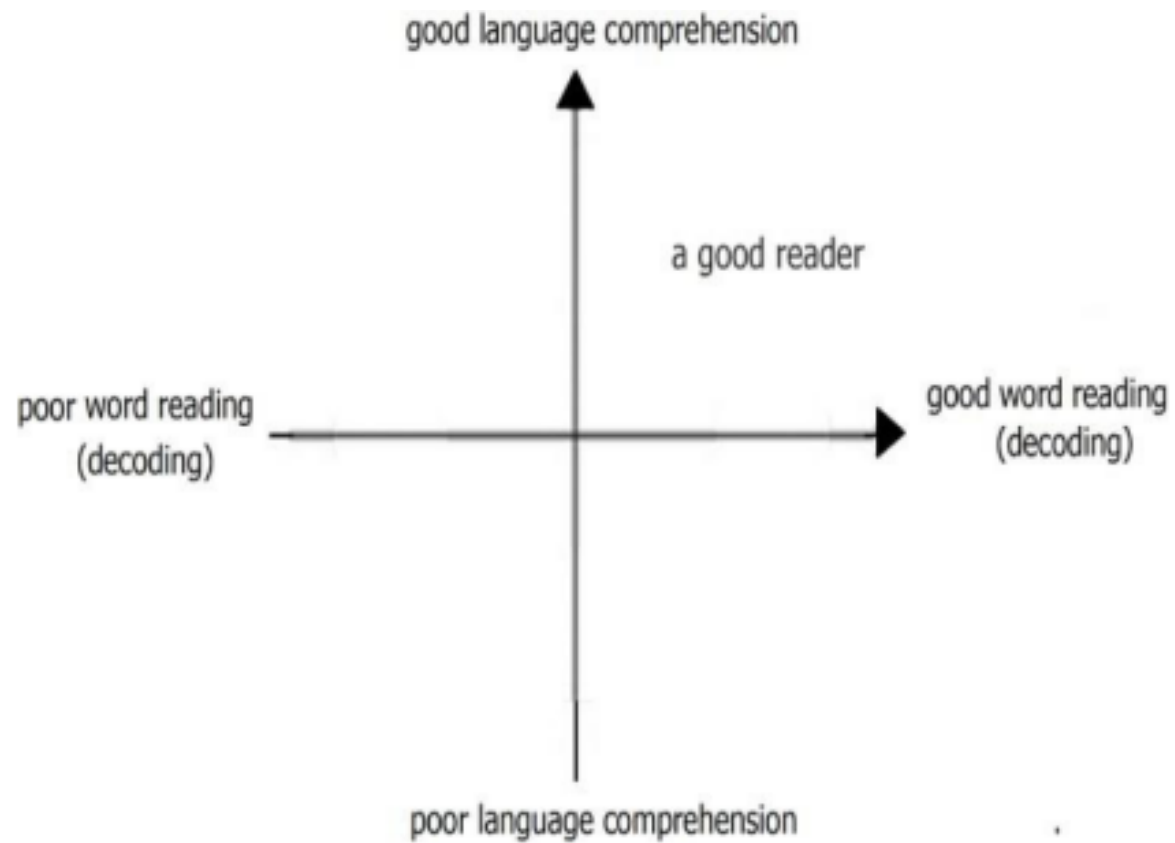
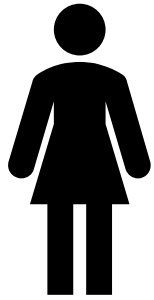
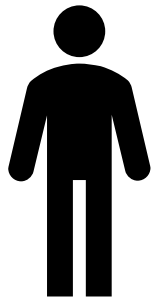


Figure 1: The knowledge of a good reader

Supporting readers: What could be done?



Mia and George are in Year 7, although they struggled with reading at primary school they did not receive the support they needed at KS2.



Mia and George are now faced with a huge amount of reading in every lesson – in one day their peers read about the Norman invasion in history, a supermarket visit in French, cell structure in biology and they read 'Macbeth' in English. Mia and George cannot achieve success at school because their progress depends upon their learning academic vocabulary – and this depends on their ability to decode new words rapidly. Their motivation to learn and attitude towards school are at the lowest possible level. They are demoralised and have become recalcitrant. They have no choice but to hide the fact they cannot read. George disrupts lessons so he can be sent out of class; Mia switches off in lessons and then copies her friend's work.

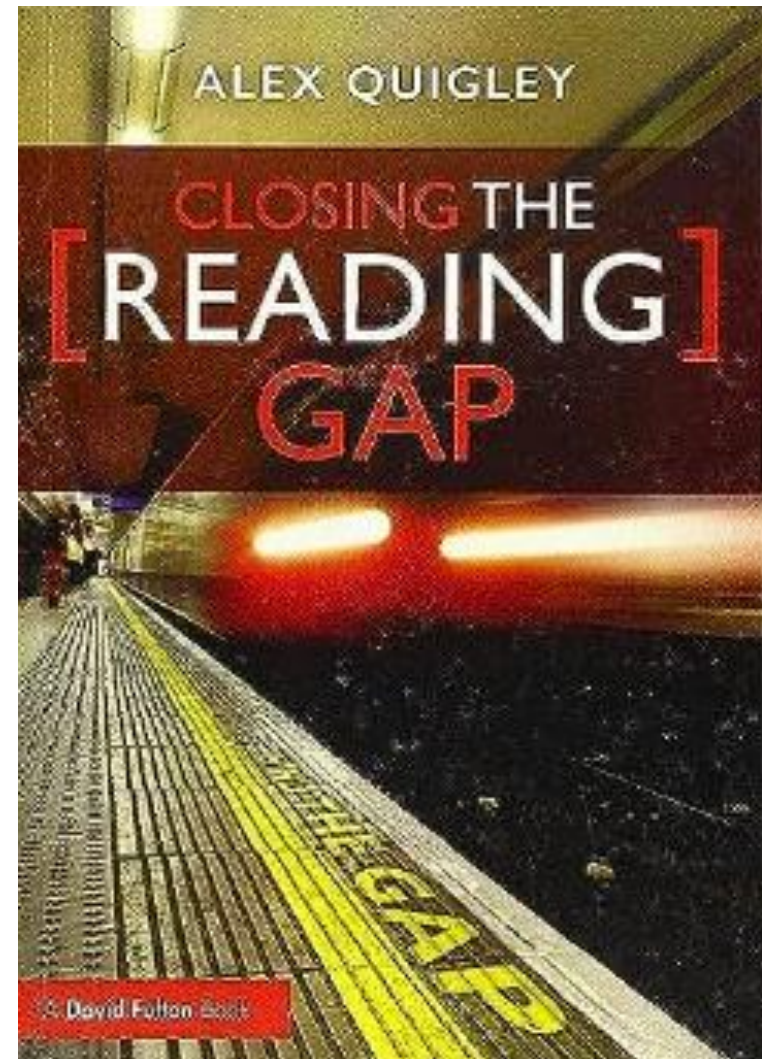
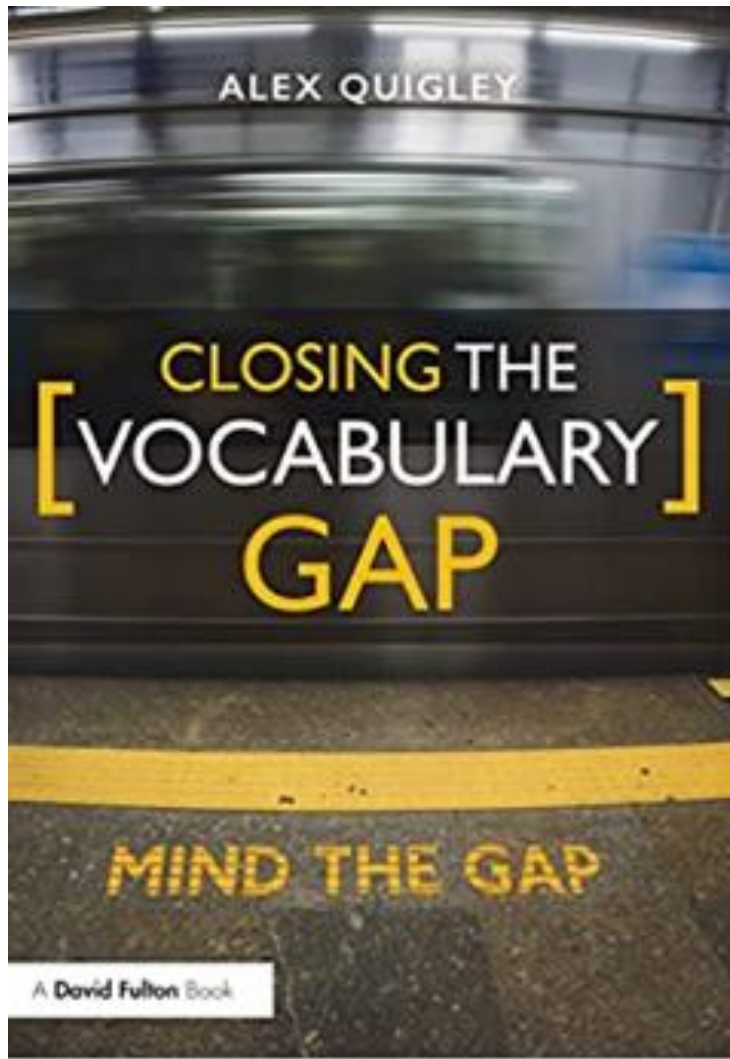
Audit: pupils who need more support

Pupils who need more support	Current practice
Assessments identify pupils with poor word reading and fluency as soon as possible.	
Sufficient support accelerates progress, including for new arrivals and pupils who are learning English as an additional language.	
Each pupil receiving daily extra support is profiled to identify any special educational needs or disability (if not already identified); any speech, communication and language needs; time at the school; their attendance, and previous teaching.	
Leaders manage the timetable effectively, so pupils receive sufficient time to catch up with their decoding and fluency. (It is likely that pupils may need to miss other lessons, or form time, while they catch up.)	
Well-trained staff make sure that pupils get effective teaching to catch up rapidly.	
Leaders support and monitor interventions closely and the impact on pupils' progress is evaluated regularly	
Actions to be taken (by term)	

(DfE, 2023, p.76)

Reading 1: Machin, S., McNally, S., & Viarengo, M. (2018) Changing how literacy is taught: Evidence on synthetic phonics. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 10(2), pp.217-241

- ‘...it is more difficult to improve the reading scores for students who speak nonstandard English at home’ (Machin, McNally and Viarengo, 2018, p240)
- ‘...closing literacy gaps based on disadvantage and (initial) language proficiency by family background’ (Machin, McNally and Viarengo, 2018, p240)

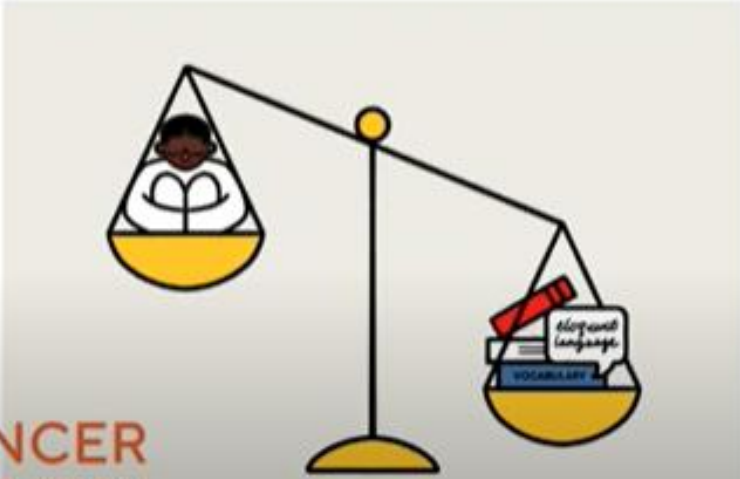


ProblematISING 'gap' discourses

PowerPoint Slide Show - [Cushing_word gap L1.M4]

Raciolinguistic ideologies and narratives of deficit: how the 'word gap' came to be normalised in England's schools

Dr Ian Cushing
Faculty of Education,
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Play (k) 1:11 / 54:35 • Intro >

Three video feeds are visible on the right side of the screen, showing participants in a virtual meeting.

Word gap ideologies are rooted in deficit perspectives of language which claim that minoritised speakers do poorly in school not because of structural inequality but because of a cultural, cognitive and linguistic deficit located within the speakers, their families, and their communities

(Cushing, 2022, p.5)



Guardian 2, 2021, London UK, digital illustration



Worthless Speech, 2021, London UK, digital illustration

The access paradox

Access to English provides students with 'linguistic capital' (Bourdieu, 1991)

'If you provide more people with access to the dominant variety of the dominant language, you contribute to perpetuating and increasing its dominance. If, on the other hand, you deny students access, you perpetuate their marginalisation in a society that continues to recognise this language as a mark of distinction.' (Janks, 2010)



How will today's session
influence your future
practice?

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